

Term Paper Checkpoint 4: Putting it all Together

At this point, you should be ready to start actually writing your term paper. But The prospect of a 4000+ word paper might still feel daunting. So in this final checkpoint, we're going to help you break it down a bit more, so that the only things left to focus on for your final term paper are flushing out the details and focusing on the actual presentation and writing.

Repeating Earlier Work

At this point, you (hopefully) have a well structured systematic + unsystematic search, proto-bibliography, point form background section, and outline of your term paper. You can still tweak any of these things, and have one more chance to get feedback before your final term paper submission.

Background Section

From your previous checkpoint, your should have ~3 sentences for each paper in your systematic and unsystematic searches. So this should be an easy section to finalize. All you need to do is put them in a sensible order, trying to group similar papers together, and maybe add a bit of connective tissue explaining what the reader should gather from viewing the papers as a group.

This should now be your final background section, ready to submit for your term paper. If you do this part right, you shouldn't need to change this for the final submission.

Bibliography

If you haven't done so already, this would be a great time to figure out how you're managing your bibliography and references. Please DO NOT just try to manage things manually. Setting a tool like BibTeX or EndNote may feel like work initially, but it will save you a lot of time and hassle in the long run. Make sure you've got a properly formed bibliography (both for the material in your background section, and for other supporting material you will be using throughout your paper), and set it up in a way that lets you easily drop references in to your outline.

Flushing Out Your Outline

In your last checkpoint, you made an outline for the sections/subsections of your paper. Now it's time to go one layer deeper. For each of the topics in your outline, add a few points to structure that subsection. As a rough guide, each bullet point here should relate to a paragraph or two in your final paper. A good structure is to add (at least) 3 bullet points for each subsection:

- Claim: The idea or opinion you're putting forward
- Evidence: The data to support that idea
- Counter: (optional) The data that refutes that idea
- Analysis: A summary of why this idea is supported and/or how it contributes to your larger claim

Some of your subtopics may take more than 3-4 points, some may take fewer, but this is a good guide to when you might need to merge subtopics, or break a subtopic down into smaller subtopics.

By the time you're done here, your major structure and flow of your essay. All that will be left is flushing out the bullet points into full paragraphs, and doing some word-smithing for presentation.

What to Submit

This time you're submitting 2 documents:

A draft of what will become your final paper, which should include:

- Your point form outline of your final paper
- Your fully flushed out backgrounds section
- Your bibliography

And a supporting appendix that includes:

- Your research questions
- Your systematic search
- Your unsystematic search
- Your CRAAP analysis for each of the documents